

Racialization and Perceived Institutional Ideology

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Abstract

The extent to which public discourse about policymaking highlights the implications of policy for racial inequality varies across contexts and over time. While some institutions are inherently more central to maintaining or reducing racial inequality than others, policymakers, the media, and advocates talk about the aims and implications of policy in different ways over time. Some may downplay the racial implications of policy while others may emphasize race, either to reduce racial inequality or increase it. While qualitative scholarship highlights the importance of institutional racialization for policy outcomes and public opinion research finds that racialization affects public support, we lack systematic measures. Using text analysis of policy documents, media coverage, and advocacy agendas, we develop new measures for the racialization of federal agencies over time. We find that racialization is not correlated with perceived liberal or conservative ideology. However, agencies perceived as more ideological—whether liberal or conservative—tend to be more racialized. We also find significant variation in racialization over time, suggesting that efforts to reform institutions and to reframe policy debates affect racialization, even when the agency’s mission and core functions largely remain the same.

Keywords: Racialization, bureaucracy, ideology, rhetoric, framing, institutions

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1 Introduction

Public policy is given effect through government institutions. As such, efforts to shape policy almost necessarily involve efforts to affect the actions of institutions, enhance or undermine their perceived legitimacy, and shape public perceptions of their role in political conflicts. Racial inequality and resentment are major drivers of policy initiatives and political behavior in many contexts, including the United States (Kinder and Sanders, 1996). Because of this, policymakers, politicians, and advocates strategically deploy racial cues to reinforce or challenge policy directions, framing institutions and their activities as aligned with—or in opposition to—specific racial and political ideologies. Likewise, policymakers and advocates may also strategically attempt to de-racialize institutions if not talking about race better advances their policy agenda. These linguistic signals in elite discourse and media narratives frame the roles of various institutions in the political landscape of their time. Measuring racialization shows how public discourse around each federal agency pays more or less attention to race over time.

We define institutional racialization as the relative extent to which the public and elite language used to describe an institution and its actions highlight implications for racialized groups. Our definition builds on the work of sociologists and political theorists on racialized cues, racial formation, and systemic racism—especially the concepts of racialization and institutional racism. Institutional racialization captures both how social structures are organized along racial lines (Omi and Winant, 2014) and how public discourse frames institutions as having greater or lesser stakes for racial inequality. One of the main ways that framing processes affect politics and policymaking is by affecting the perceived stakes of policy (Woodly, 2015).

Racialization and de-racialization may have different implications for institutional racism at different times. Bonilla-Silva (2022) emphasizes that racism is a system of practices that produces and sustains racial structures, impacting life chances by providing advantages to dominant racial groups and disadvantages to others. Talking about race may serve to reduce structural advantages by paying attention to them (e.g., civil rights enforcement, studies, or disproportionate impact across racial groups). Alternatively, highlighting race may increase structural advantage (e.g., authorizing racial profiling or framing social assistance policies as a handout to Black people was a way of mobilizing White racial resentment to undermine the policy).

Our definition is an attempt to synthesize contributions in a way that allows systematic measurement of how organizations are organized along racial lines through public discourse.

Racialization plays a key role in efforts to reshape government institutions. For example, approximately half of the Biden Administration’s executive orders instructed agencies to initiate civil rights-related actions, many explicitly demanding attention to race. Several “whole-of-government” initiatives included instructions

to agencies that had not previously highlighted the racial implications of their policies and programs to hire staff to assess the impacts of the agency's actions on racial inequalities. This included a 2021 executive order titled Advancing Racial Equity and Support for Underserved Communities Through the Federal Government, which initiated efforts to increase racial equity across federal institutions. Other initiatives, such as restricting immigration by refusing to process asylum claims, were arguably driven by a resurgence of racial resentments generated by successful efforts to re-racialize immigration policy. Immigration policy began as explicitly racial exclusion, then underwent reforms that de-emphasized racial implications, and is now increasingly racialized again.

In January 2025, the Trump Administration issued the "Ending Radical and Wasteful Government DEI Programs and Preferencing" executive order, initiating efforts to dismantle diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility (DEIA) practices within federal agencies. This executive order instructs agency heads to end efforts to reduce patterns of racial exclusion in the federal workforce. In tandem with this order, numerous federal employees whose jobs included attention to racial diversity, equity, or inclusion were targeted and abruptly dismissed. In parallel, significant budget cuts targeted programs and institutions researching racial inequalities and patterns of exclusion. Funding for initiatives promoting racial equity has been severely restricted, limiting their ability to function and fulfill their missions. These initiatives were largely aligned with the language and goals of the Heritage Foundation's Project 2025, which outlined policies designed to reduce attention to racial inequity in the work of federal government institutions.

In other ways, attention to race increased under the Trump administration. Departing from the longstanding practice of law enforcement denying accusations of racial profiling, the administration defended racial profiling as legal if related to immigrant capture and removal operations. At the same time, the US State Department and US Customs and Immigration Service (USCIS) justified prioritizing White South Africans because they allegedly face racial discrimination. Likewise, the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) invested resources in encouraging White Americans to bring claims of reverse discrimination. The EEOC also reclassified employer efforts to prevent discrimination and create inclusive workplaces as discrimination against White men.

The common theme in these examples is reforms and scrutiny targeting specific federal agencies by framing the institution within the context of racial politics or by de-emphasizing that frame. The language used by policymakers, politicians, advocates, and the media to describe agencies highlights how specific agencies are racialized or deracialized in order to advance various policy goals. This raises important descriptive questions, such as (1) *How consistent is racialization in different contexts (e.g., the media, advocacy, and policymaking),* (2) *How*

consistent is racialization over time? (3) Do perceptions of racialization differ across agencies typically seen as either conservative or liberal?

To help scholars address these questions, this paper develops measures of institutional racialization, capturing when race becomes a salient dimension of discourse surrounding federal agencies. Using a large corpus of media coverage, policy documents, and discourse in Project 2025, the measure captures when agencies are discussed in relation to racialized language. By identifying these moments, the paper provides a way to observe how bureaucratic institutions become embedded in broader political conversations over race.

We use data from advocacy groups, news media, and policy documents from agencies themselves. We identify 96,676 instances of agencies using or being discussed with racial language, including 851 paragraphs in the Heritage Foundation’s Project 2025 Mandate for Leadership report, 38,965 articles in the New York Times, and 56,860 agency rules. By scaling the relative frequency that each source does and does not use racialized language when talking about an agency or its policies, we show which agencies are relatively more racialized within and across realms of public discourse. Our new measures also offer a temporal lens through which to understand how both liberal and conservative institutions are perceived as racialized, particularly in the framing of agencies in terms that reflect racial tension, mitigation, or attention.

For example, immigration policy can be discussed in ways that undermine racial hierarchy (“we are a nation of immigrants”), reinforce it (“immigration enforcement protects America for Heritage Americans”) or in more neutral ways (“USCIS facilitates an orderly process of immigration and naturalization.”) Our hope is that our measure distinguishes the racialized (the first two) from the latter. By doing so, the paper adds a new dimension to the study of bureaucratic politics and provides a tool for examining how racial conflict shapes policy debates and executive governance.

Education policy has also seen differences in racialization. For a time, federal education policy did not interfere with school segregation. Then that changed, and federal education policy focused on racial desegregation and equal treatment. Backlash to diversity and equity-oriented education policy focused on preventing the consideration of race in admissions. While nominally promoting “race-neutral” policy, the government must speak about race in order to bar private entities, like universities, from considering race. From the government’s perspective, the policy of preventing the consideration of race in university admissions is the government attending to race. If this gloss were reflected in the data, we should see the Department of Education becoming sharply more racialized with federally-forced desegregation, tapering off with decreased emphasis on segregation and more neutral emphasis on equal opportunity, and then an increase as fights over diversity, equity, and inclusion policies emerge.

Measuring racial discourse surrounding federal agencies is important because visibility is a necessary precursor to accountability. Scholars and policymakers cannot evaluate whether government institutions reinforce or dismantle racial hierarchies if implications for racial equity remain difficult to observe. By identifying when race becomes visible, or when efforts are made to remove racial language from policy discussions, this measure provides a new empirical lens for studying how racial politics shape the administrative state.

We show that racialization is distinct from political ideology. Racialization is correlated with perceptions of ideological extremism—agencies perceived as further from the political center tend to also be more racialized—but this relationship is only statistically significant ($p < 0.05$) in the Project 2025 Mandate for Leadership text.

2 Why Measure Racialization?

Race has long shaped American public policy, yet we know surprisingly little about when race becomes visible within the everyday discourse surrounding federal agencies. Scholars have documented racial inequalities in policy outcomes and examined representation within government institutions, but far less attention has been paid to how race enters policy debates surrounding the administrative state itself. At times, federal agencies become focal points of racialized political conflict, such as debates over affirmative action, immigration enforcement, civil rights protections, or diversity initiatives. At other moments, race appears largely absent from discussions of government activity. These shifts raise an important question: when and why do federal agencies become embedded in racial politics?

Existing research provides important insights into how public policy shapes racial inequality and how representation within institutions influences governance. However, scholars lack systematic tools for observing when race becomes visible within the discourse surrounding bureaucratic institutions themselves. As a result, it is difficult to identify when agencies become sites of racialized political conflict or when political actors attempt to redefine, suppress, or redirect discussions of race in governance.

2.1 Causes of Racialization

Racial language can emerge in discussions of federal agencies for several reasons. First, agencies may become racialized when they are responsible for policies that explicitly address racial inequality, such as civil rights enforcement or affirmative action. Second, agencies may become symbolically associated with particular racial groups or racialized policy domains, leading political actors and the public to interpret their activities through a racial lens. Third, racial discourse may emerge during moments of political backlash or contestation, including efforts to challenge or eliminate diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives. Together, these dynamics illustrate how agencies become racialized not only through the policies they implement, but also through political struggles over how race should be addressed within governance.

In some cases, racial language reflects policy efforts aimed at expanding opportunity or addressing historical disparities. Discussions of affirmative action within the Department of Education, for example, often involve explicit references to race as policymakers debate how to improve access to higher education for communities of color.

In other cases, racial language appears in a descriptive or analytic context. For example, in discussions of transportation policy, for instance, may reference racial demographics when examining which communities are most affected by infrastructure investments or environmental impacts. Here, race functions primarily as a demographic category rather than as the central focus of political conflict.

As noted above, during moments of political contestation or major events, racial language can be deployed in harmful or explicitly discriminatory ways. Following September 11th, debates over transportation security frequently relied on racialized language targeting specific communities, framing them as sources of suspicion or threat. These narratives reinforced stereotypes and legitimized surveillance and profiling, demonstrating that increases in racial language do not merely reflect discussions about race—they can also signal the racialization of policy debates in ways that reproduce inequality and harm.

2.2 Why Racialization Matters

Exclusionary practices are deeply ingrained in American institutions. Racial politics were central to the construction of the bureaucracy (Van Riper, 1958, Ross (1975), Walton (1988), Ingraham and Rosenbloom (1992)) and the historical alignment of party coalitions along racial lines (Schickler, 2016).

The development of racialized rhetoric and perceptions of race in understanding federal agencies must be contextualized within the historical evolution of bureaucracies as racialized institutions across perceived ideological lines. This continuity reveals that many patterns we observe today are not new but repackaged versions of longstanding dynamics. By distinguishing racialization from the measurement of federal agencies as liberal or conservative, we gain a deeper understanding of how this relates to their history of racial cues, signaling, and distancing among both conservative and liberal efforts.

Federal agencies have never been racially neutral; they were deeply segregated institutions that enforced exclusionary policies, disadvantaging racial minorities and positioning agencies as racialized actors. As federal agencies have changed and reshaped over time, so too has the racial landscape in the United States. Understanding how agencies become racialized requires examining both their historical role in racial inequality and how diversity within agencies influences the policies they implement. The importance of our measure lies in its ability to capture how perceptions of these agencies have evolved.

Agencies Make Policies that Shape Racial Inequality

Federal agencies are not neutral entities; their structures, leadership composition, and policy responsibilities shape racial outcomes.

King (1999) illustrates this, explaining that “the role of the federal bureaucracy as a complicit agent in segregated race relations demonstrates how governments, often manipulated by the promoters of special interests, become conduits (at the least) of illiberalism. The legacies of racial segregation and of the federal government’s involvement in their maintenance and perpetuation have been elemental to US politics”.

Representative Bureaucracy and Segregation in the Federal Workforce

The diversity within agencies, particularly in terms of race, ethnicity, and gender, further affects the types of policies they administer. Regulatory and law enforcement-related agencies have historically been and continue to be disproportionately represented by White men. On the other hand, redistribution agencies, like the Department of Education, Health and Human Services, and Housing and Urban Development, tend to have a more diverse workforce that mirrors the US population (Choi and Rainey, 2010).

The representative bureaucracy literature has shown that diversity and demographics both influence and reflect policies that align with the composition of an agency’s workforce (Mansbridge, 1999; Watkins-Hayes, 2009; Minta, 2009; Juenke and Preuhs, 2012; Hayes and Hibbing, 2017; Meier, 2019). This suggests that agency structures, as King describes, not only reflect historical racial legacies but also influence the degree to which agencies are racialized in terms of both policy and representation.

President Wilson explicitly endorsed a segregated federal government, framing his segregationist ideals as beneficial for African Americans and women. The Wilson administration’s discriminatory hiring practices were entrenched in the civil service, making merit-based entry difficult. For example, in 1914, the US Civil Service Commission required applicants for civil service posts to supply a photograph with their application form (Van Riper, 1958; King, 1999; Blatt, 2018). The Roosevelt administration also created racialized agencies like the National Youth Administration’s (NYA) Division of Negro Affairs and the “Black Cabinet.” These efforts, while pivotal for racial and gender representation, were short-lived and were the terms of segregation (Ross, 1975; King, 1999).

Agency structures, workforce composition, and policy responsibilities both reflect and reproduce racial hierarchies, making some agencies more likely to become sites of racialized attention or contestation. Understanding these dynamics is critical because contemporary discussions of agencies, whether in policymaking, media coverage, or advocacy, often draw on or reflect these historical patterns.

Historical Legacies and Institutional Racialization

Organizations function as racial structures where rules and resources are connected through cognitive schema (Ray, 2019). The sustainability and protection of agencies that serve diverse populations are deeply connected to the historical development of US bureaucracies, which were heavily shaped by anti-Black sentiments and segregationist values. Additionally, pivotal historical moments have simultaneously influenced the broader politics of racialization, making it essential to consider how the public and elites perceive federal agencies, policy preferences, and the agents involved in policymaking.

Scholars have identified the New Deal era as a pivotal moment in the racial realignment of party coalitions and the racialization of politics. The New Deal and the Civil Rights Movement have had lasting effects, including partisan sorting and polarization, which significantly impacted the racial sorting within the Republican and Democratic Party coalitions. In *Steadfast Democrats: How Social Forces Shape Black Political Behavior*, White and Laird specifically address the development of Black Americans' support for the Democratic Party. They examine how this support has remained steadfast since the post-Civil Rights era and how affiliation with the Democratic Party now aligns with the social expectations of Black Americans (Schickler, 2016; Tate, 2003; White and Laird, 2020).

The well-documented alignment between race, party, and ideology, reflected in consistent patterns of voting behavior and public opinion, likely extends beyond electoral politics to shape federal institutions themselves. If racialized patterns in society influence which policies are prioritized, how agencies are structured, and who staffs them, then federal agencies are not only administrative bodies but may also be sites where the effects of racial realignment are embedded and reproduced. This makes the racialization of agencies a critical phenomenon to measure, as it captures how historical legacies, partisan sorting, and societal racial dynamics intersect to shape contemporary perceptions, policy debates, and agency behavior.

Talking about Race Affects Policy Support

Public opinion and political behavior research on race and ethnicity scholarship shows that liberal-conservative measures of ideology may overlook the profound impact of racialized frames on policy preferences. Public opinion scholars have shown that racial attitudes are strongly correlated with policy preferences on issues like anti-discrimination, immigration, and race-targeted programs. While race and ethnic politics scholars in Political Science use various methods to test the causes of racial polarization, one indisputable fact is that it exists. Hutchings and Valentino (2004) explain how “the ‘Goldwater gamble’ in 1964, based on opposition to federal intervention to protect blacks’ civil rights, triggered a heightened emphasis on race in the two parties’

platforms, increased polarization of party activists on racial issues, and polarized mass perceptions of the two parties on desegregation.”

The role of race is essential in discussions about polarization and ideology within the administrative government. In contemporary politics, polarization is closely intertwined with race, which may be shaping both public and elite perceptions of agency ideology and the policies they enforce. O’Brian (2024) shows that polarization among elites and the public is heavily shaped by the racial alignment of parties, and this racial alignment triggers broader culture wars in the United States, such as issues on abortion and gun control.

Moreover, a January 2020 survey of Republicans and Republican-leaning Independents aimed at understanding antidemocratic sentiments, such as partisan effects, enthusiasm for Trump, and more, reveals that ethnic antagonism is the strongest correlation (Bartels, 2020). The findings underscore the importance of race in understanding political perceptions, showing that by engaging with race, we gain insight beyond the common scales of party ideology. Bartels (2020) found that the single survey item with the highest average correlation with antidemocratic sentiments is not a measure of attitudes toward Trump, but an item inviting respondents to agree that “discrimination against whites is as big a problem today as discrimination against blacks and other minorities.”

These findings suggest that understanding the racialization of political institutions moves us beyond the conventional liberal–conservative spectrum. Developing a metric that captures these dynamics can help scholars observe how key actors in the rulemaking process are framed by elites and the public, and whether federal agencies themselves are positioned as drivers of racialized governance across the political aisle.

Institutions, however, are not only ideological actors; they also operate within broader social and political discourses that shape how policies are debated and implemented. Research on language and political discourse highlights that words are not merely descriptive but are deeply embedded in systems of power and social meaning. As McConnell-Ginet (2020) argues, language “brings into the light of day attitudes, assumptions, and actions that ground social relations and arrangements,” making discourse a key mechanism through which power relations are expressed and contested. Similarly, Woodly (2015) and Woodly (2022) demonstrate that public discourse plays a central role in shaping political identities and policy debates, particularly around race, while additionally Adediran (2026) shows that institutional language can influence how societies understand and respond to racial inequality. Taken together, this scholarship suggests that examining the language surrounding government institutions can reveal important political dynamics that might otherwise remain obscured. Moreover, Doane (2006) highlights that racial discourse itself is politically contested and strategically deployed in public debates, reinforcing the idea that language surrounding race reflects broader struggles over how racial issues are defined and addressed.

The power of rhetoric in policy texts is critical to understanding what may influence a federal agency's perceived ideology. Many policy preferences can be tied back to major policies that are considered contentious or divisive. Stephens-Dougan (2020) defines *rhetorical strategy* as involving verbal cues that distance politicians from racial and ethnic minorities, either through explicit references (e.g., "African American" or "Latino") or implicit, coded language (e.g., "inner city" or "tough on crime") that associates issues like crime or welfare with racial minorities. (Stephens-Dougan, 2020; Gilens, 1999).

Gilens (1999) finds that in a 1994 CBS and New York Times survey, "55 percent of the respondents said that most people on welfare are black, and these respondents hold consistently more negative views about welfare recipients' true needs and their commitment to the work ethic than do respondents who think that most welfare recipients are white."

These findings align with subsequent research by Tesler (2012), who demonstrates that Obama's association with healthcare policies, such as "Obamacare," and media coverage on these issues played a significant role in widening the gap between Black and White Americans' healthcare policy preferences. Using survey experiments, Tesler provides insights into why the racial divide on healthcare opinion grew by 20 percentage points, a larger divide than what was seen during the Clinton presidency. His findings support the argument that racial attitudes were a significant driver of this divide.

Clinton's rhetoric and framing around welfare, interestingly, were strategic in signaling his racial distancing from Black Americans while reinforcing stereotypes about them and their relationship with welfare. Smith (2008) highlights how Clinton's strategy reflected Thomas Edsall's argument (Washington Post report) that the Democratic Party should shift focus from issues of racism, poverty, affirmative action, and civil rights to middle-class concerns, such as lower taxes and a tough approach to welfare. As part of this strategy, Clinton frequently used the phrase "opportunity plus responsibility" in 1992, subtly appealing to White voters' views that Black Americans were irresponsible, lazy, and preferred welfare over work. This illustrates how both Republican and Democratic administrations have used racialized language in framing policy issues, which influences public perceptions and garners media attention, underscoring the need to include racialization as a metric to fully grasp its impact on agency perceptions.

Though Schneider and Ingram (1993) does not fully engage with the nuances of systemic racism or critically examine how race is socially constructed, their analysis in "Social Construction of Target Populations: Implications for Politics and Policy" offers valuable insights into the role of language in policymaking. They highlight how policy recipients are categorized and treated differently based on constructed narratives. As they argue, "Citizens encounter and internalize the messages not only through observation of politics and media coverage but also through their direct, personal experiences with public policy. These experiences tell them whether

they are viewed as ‘clients’ by government and bureaucracies or whether they are treated as objects.” Despite these limitations, their work contributes to understanding the role of language in policymaking and how policy shapes public perceptions. However, the framework falls short in addressing how anti-Blackness and racial hierarchies explicitly structure these categorizations, leaving room for expansion through insights from racial and critical policy studies.

Additionally, the dynamics of race, policy, and language are not confined to the United States; similar patterns can be observed globally. For example, in the United Kingdom around 2010–2012, Prime Minister Cameron’s declaration that “multiculturalism is dead” and Home Secretary May’s statement that “equality is a dirty word” underscore shifts in the political climate, where policies addressing racial inequalities were downgraded. This mirrors similar rhetoric in the United States, where political elites craft rhetoric to target federal agencies. [Craig \(2013\)](#) explains that “the Government Equalities Office, responsible for ensuring equalities work within government, has had its budget reduced by almost 50%.” The government’s cuts to BME (Black and minority ethnic) networks and the removal of race-focused commissioners at the Equality and Human Rights Commission (EHRC) further highlight how racialized policymaking and the politics of race are global phenomena that require a broader critical framework for understanding ([Craig, 2013](#)).

Building on these insights, we introduce a measure of agency racialization that captures when and how racial language becomes associated with federal agencies in public discourse. This approach provides a new lens for understanding bureaucratic politics by revealing when agencies become sites of racialized political conflict. In doing so, it complements existing measures of agency ideology and offers new insight into the dynamics of executive governance and policy debate.

2.3 Racialization and Ideology

Existing measures of agency ideology have advanced our understanding of bureaucratic politics by placing agencies along a liberal–conservative dimension. However, ideological positioning alone cannot fully capture the political dynamics surrounding many federal agencies. Agencies frequently become focal points of racialized policy conflict, particularly when their activities intersect with debates over civil rights or immigration.

Scholars of bureaucratic politics have made significant advances in measuring the ideological positions of federal agencies to better understand regulatory output, executive control, and policy outcomes ([Brierley et al., 2023](#)). Methodological approaches to measuring agency ideology vary widely, including expert surveys, presidential appointments, appointee campaign contributions, and analyses of unionization and agency leadership ([Clinton and Lewis, 2008](#); [Richardson, 2019](#); [Epstein and O’Halloran, 1999](#); [Nixon, 2004](#); [Chen and Johnson, 2014](#); [Maranto, 2005](#); [Maranto and Hult, 2004](#); [Bertelli and Grose, 2011](#)). For example, [Acs \(2025\)](#) develops

dynamic estimates of agency ideal points, showing how agencies' ideological alignment with the president shapes regulatory productivity over time. [Chen and Johnson \(2014\)](#) shows that unionization occurs more frequently under presidents whose political ideologies are closely aligned with the agency, influencing both turnover and ideological orientation. Similarly, [Lavertu and Yackee \(2014\)](#) finds that managers in liberal agencies reported greater effort on the Bush administration's PART review than those in conservative agencies, reflecting both programmatic demands and the ideological beliefs of employees.

Surveys of agency experts and civil servants further illustrate the complexities of ideological perception. [Clinton and Lewis \(2008\)](#) measured agency preferences through expert surveys conducted in 1988 and 2005, using bureaucratic experts to rank 82 executive agencies on a liberal-to-conservative spectrum. This study, based on the assessments of 37 experts from academia, journalism, and Washington think tanks, provided key insights into the ideological landscape of federal agencies. Building on this work, [Richardson \(2019\)](#) expanded the survey to include more agencies and 1,500 federal executives with government experience, further refining the understanding of agency liberalism and conservatism. In estimating agency preferences, their work offers insight into the potential drivers of agency liberalism and conservatism.

In a more recent study, [Richardson \(2024\)](#) conducted an original online survey of civil servants from executive departments, independent agencies, and the Executive Office of the President (EOP). The study asked respondents to evaluate partisan disagreement within their agencies, providing a latent measure of agency ideology. The findings reveal that agencies with similar ideological estimates, such as the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB) on the liberal end and the Air Force, Army, and Navy on the conservative end, experience varying levels of partisan disagreement. While liberal agencies like the EPA face higher levels of partisan conflict, similarly liberal organizations like the Peace Corps do not. On the conservative side, the Air Force and Army face less partisan disagreement than agencies like United States Customs and Border Protection (USCBP) or the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms, and Explosives (ATF), despite sharing conservative ideology estimates ([Richardson, 2024](#)). This variation suggests that perceived ideological alignment alone does not explain why certain agencies experience more political conflict, thus leaving opportunities to further explore what it means to be a "liberal" and "conservative" agency and why certain agencies experience more partisan contention. Institutions' stated and perceived roles in racial politics may help address this gap.

Understanding the perceived liberal or conservative leanings of agencies helps explain why certain institutions become contentious or targeted for reform. Racialization may interact with these ideological perceptions, potentially influencing how agencies are seen as more extreme. It may also provide distinct insights into the political landscape surrounding debates over federal policy and the institutions that execute it. For example,

an agency like the Department of Defense may be viewed as conservative, but a new administration could implement policies that address racial inequities within its structure. Even agencies perceived as conservative can experience internal conflicts, exposing tensions surrounding race. A key contribution of our measure is its ability to capture the prominence of these debates—the push and pull between efforts to either mitigate or obstruct racial progress.

In the next section, we develop measures of racialization that may contribute to understanding variation in partisan disagreement that is not explained by measures of liberal-conservative. Using text analysis of language that cues race, we aim to capture public, policymaker, and elite perceptions of agency levels in which an agency is classified as “racialized”, offering a new lens that may be missing from traditional scales of liberalism and conservatism.

3 Data and Measurement

To construct a measure of agency rationalization, we use a dictionary-based method to quantify racialized rhetoric used in sources that allow relatively systematic coverage of federal agencies. To date, these sources are The Heritage Foundation’s 2024 Mandate for Leadership report, agency rules, and New York Times articles mentioning agency names. Each source captures a different context where racialized rhetoric may have different meanings. This allows us to compare institutional racialization across sources and also to triangulate a combined measure that captures racialization across venues, effectively upweighting racialization scores for agencies that are racialized in multiple contexts and downweighting scores for agencies that are racialized in fewer contexts.

Drawing on prior work developing dictionaries of racialized language and a careful validation process, we search documents for the following set of terms:

Affirmative Action; African American; African Americans; Africans; Alaskan Native; Alien; American Indian; Anti-discrimination; Anti-racism; Anti-racist; Antidiscrimination; Antiracism; Antiracist; Arab American; Arabs; Asian American; Asians; BIPOC; Biracial; Black American; Black Americans; Black children; Black lives; Black Man; Black Men; Black People; Black Person; Black Students; Black Woman; Black Women; Border Crisis; Citizenship; Civil Rights; Color of their skin; Colorism; Communities of Color; Critical Race Theory; Cultural competence; Culturally competent; D.E.I.; DACA; DEI; Diversity and inclusion; Diversity Equity; Diversity lottery; Diversity objectives; Diversity officer; Diversity visa; Diversity, Equity; Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion; Drug Cartel; Enslavement; Equal Opportunity; Equity agenda; Ethnic; Ethnic Diversity; Ethnicity; Gang; HBCU; Hispanic; Historically Black College and University; Illegal Alien; Illegal aliens; Illegal Immigrant; Illegal immigrants; Illegal immigration; Illegal migration; Immigrant; Immigra-

tion; Indian Education; Indigenous groups; Indigenous people; Indigenous peoples; Indigenous person; Inequality; Inequitable; Intersectionality; Latina; Latinas; Latino; Latinos; Latinx; Men of Color; Meritocracy; Mexican Cartel; Mexican Drug Cartel; Mexicans; Middle Eastern or North African Ancestry; Migrant; Minority Populations; Minority status; Minority-Serving; Mixed race; Mixed-race; Multicultural; Multiracial; Muslim; Nationality; Native American; Native-Serving; Non-white; Nonminority; Oppression; Oppressors; Pacific Islander; People of Color; People of Minority Status; Person of Color; Predominately white; Prejudice; Puerto Ricans; Racial; Racial Diversity; Racial Identity; Racial Inequality; Racial Inequities; Racial Injustices; Racial Justice; Racially; Racism; Racist; Secure Border; Secure the Border; Securing the Border; Skin color; Slavery; Social Justice; Socioeconomic; Socioeconomically; South Asian American; South Asians; Stereotypes; Structural Racism; Systemic Racism; Tribal; Tribe; Tribes; Unaccompanied Alien Children; Underrepresented Communities; Underrepresented Minorities; Underserved Communities; Underserved Populations; Vulnerable populations; White American; White Americans; White institutions; White People; White Person; White Privilege; White students; White supremacist; White supremacy; Woke; Wokeism; Women of Color; Xenophobia; Xenophobic

We validated these terms by searching the text of Mandate for Leadership reports, news articles, and regulation.gov for candidate terms and inspecting the documents returned. We excluded candidate terms that returned a significant share of documents where the term was not used with a racialized meaning.

3.1 Mandate For Leadership Reports

Context

The Heritage Foundation gained media attention and shaped public discussions of institutional reform with its recent *Project 2025* report, published in 2024. This report is part of their broader Mandate for Leadership series, which began in 1981 to provide policy recommendations for incoming Republican administrations. The structure of these reports has remained consistent over the years: they offer policy suggestions organized by targeting specific federal agencies. According to the Heritage Foundation’s website, the Mandate for Leadership “is an agenda prepared by and for conservatives who will be ready on Day One of the next administration to save our country”.

The Mandate for Leadership series has significantly shaped conservative policy. For example, [Horton \(2005\)](#) documents how the Heritage Foundation had an influential role in attacking affirmative action.

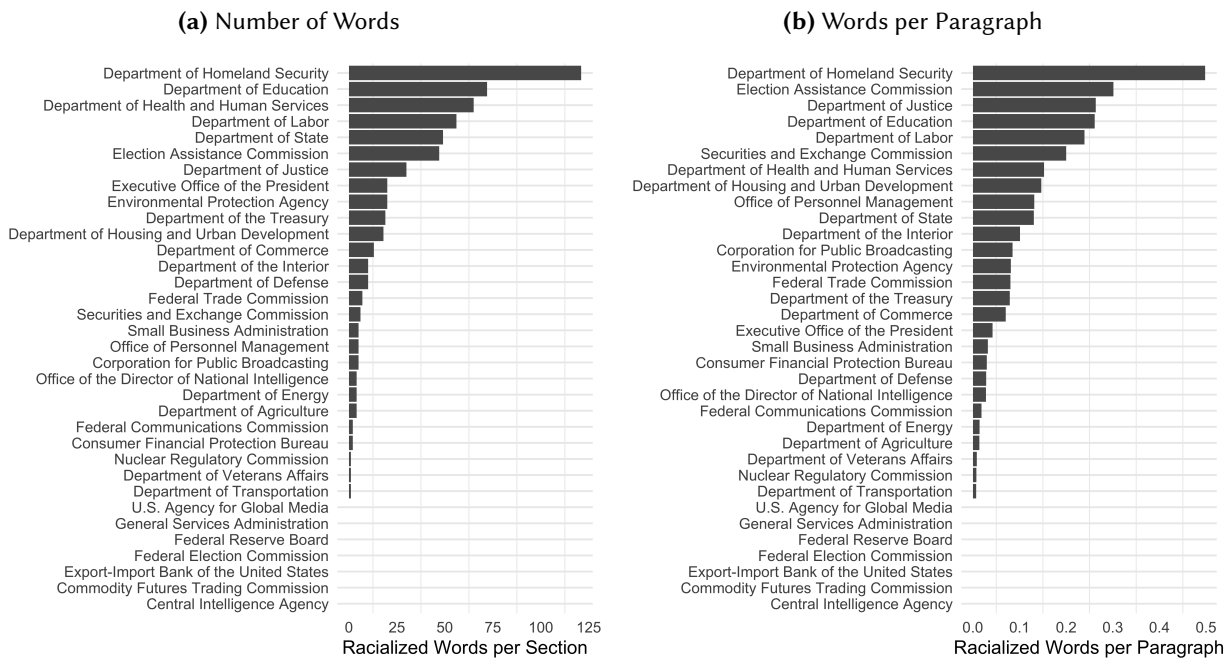
“Ten days after President Ronald Reagan assumed office,... a report entitled *Mandate for Leadership: Policy Management in a Conservative Administration...* which detailed recommendations for virtually every federal agency, *including those responsible for civil rights policy*. This work, along with its later companion volume, *Mandate for Leadership II: Continuing the Conservative Revolution*, represented, according to one highly placed journalist, one of the most ‘*widely circulated*’ documents in Washington during the early to mid-1980s.”

The impact of the *Mandate for Leadership* on the second Trump administration is evident in executive orders, budget cuts, firing patterns, and rhetoric targeting federal agencies that Project 2025 accused of advancing the so-called “woke” agenda.

Data

To create a measure of racialization in *Mandate for Leadership* Reports, we parsed the portion of the text that discussed proposed reforms to each agency by subheadings and hand-coded which agency was the primary subject of each section (most subheadings are the names of agencies or offices).¹

Figure 1: Racialized Words in Project 2025 Mandate For Leadership



We create two measures of racialization. First, we measure the *level* of racialization as the scaled total count of racialized terms used in the section on each agency. Second, we measure relative racialization by dividing this

¹We created an alternative measure based on which agency names or acronyms were mentioned in each paragraph. Since most paragraphs focus on a single agency, this measure was not substantially different.

count by the number of paragraphs in each section, approximately measuring the average *share* of paragraphs using racialized terms. We then scale both of these measures by taking the square root of the count (to stabilize the variance), subtracting the mean (to make the scale mean 0), and dividing by the standard deviation (to make the standard deviation 1).

3.2 News Coverage of Agencies

Context

Walter Lippmann's assertion remains pertinent today: our opinions and beliefs extend far beyond our direct observations and are intricately woven from the reports and narratives disseminated by the mass media. By examining the historical trajectory of poverty coverage and its implications, Gilen underscores the profound influence wielded by media narratives in shaping societal attitudes, policy debates, and perceptions of marginalized communities. "When magazine readers or television viewers see blacks depicted more often as the undeserving poor and whites as the deserving poor, they are likely to form their own stereotypes about race and poverty. And just as news professionals may be unconscious of the stereotypes that shape the content of their coverage, so magazine readers and television viewers may be unaware of the stereotypes that they acquire based on the way poverty is portrayed in the news" (Gilen, 1999).

Kellstedt (2003) and Hutchings and Valentino (2004) suggest that long-term patterns in media framing play a significant role in shaping public attitudes on race. As egalitarian framing in media coverage declined in the 1970s, so did racial liberalism and support for policies like affirmative action. For example, Jardina and Piston (2022), using survey data, find that dehumanizing racial attitudes toward Black individuals remain prevalent among the White electorate. They link these attitudes to racial messaging by elite politicians, stating, "Many Whites with beliefs aligned with White supremacist groups held top positions in the Trump administration... Figures associated with the alt-right, like Richard Spencer, have brought claims of racial differences into the mainstream, receiving substantial media attention from outlets like The New York Times and NPR. We suspect this coverage legitimizes erroneous beliefs among White Americans" (Jardina and Piston, 2022).

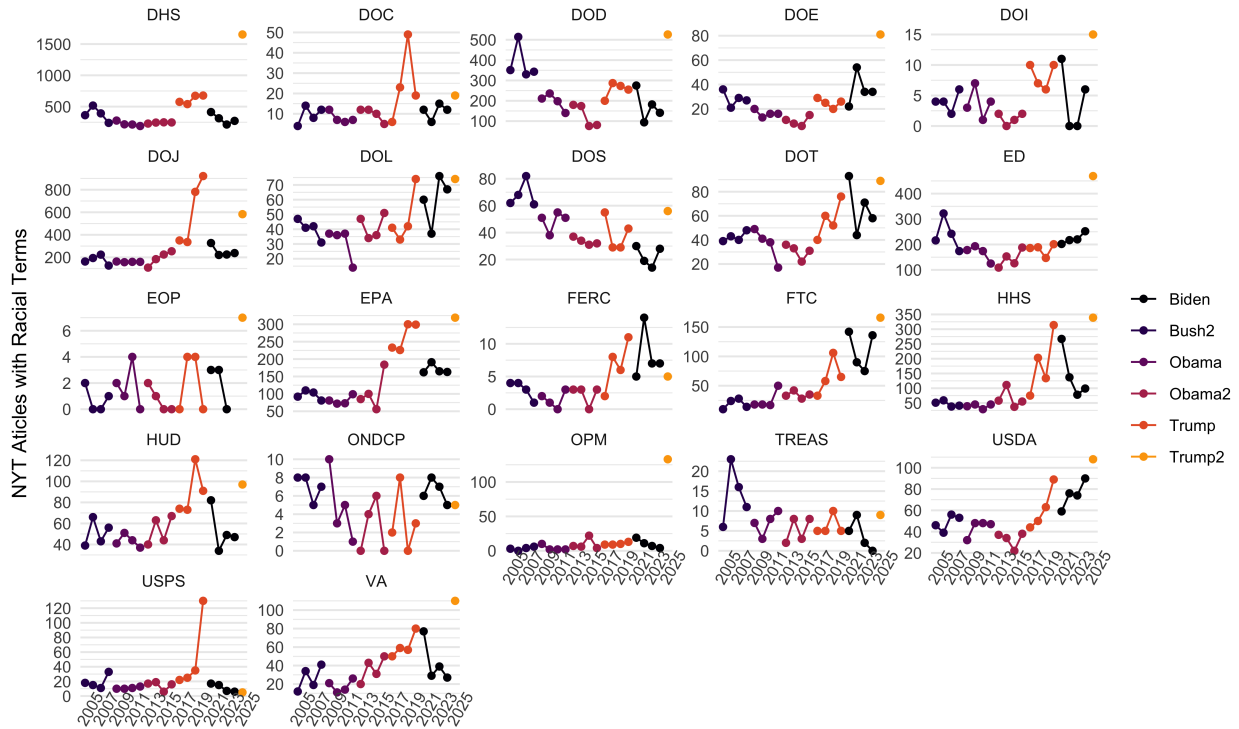
Data

Using ProQuest's Text and Data Mining tool, we identified 146,491 articles mentioning agency names in the New York Times. The New York Times dataset currently includes 22 agencies, focusing primarily on cabinet agencies and other major federal agencies. The data include a unique article ID, publication date, and article title for every article mentioning the agency name.

Of these articles mentioning federal agencies, we then identified all articles that also mention a term from our dictionary of racialized terms, such as "Affirmative Action" or "racial." This process provides a count of agency mentions and key terms, along with the key sentences containing the specified term. Of these 146,491 articles, 38,965 also mentioned the word "racial."

Over Time Trends Figure 2 shows the number of articles containing racialized terms by year for selected agencies. Figure 3 shows the same trend as Figure 2 aggregated across agencies. Overall, the frequency of racialized articles mentioning agencies peaked in 2025, with the second highest being in 2020, the end of the first Trump Administration. The peak in 2025 reflects news coverage of the administration’s aggressive policy agenda targeting immigrants and non-white Americans and policies encouraging racial diversity, equity, and inclusion. The peak in 2020 likely reflects the larger national racial reckoning in US public discourse ignited by the police killings of Black individuals and subsequent racial justice protests.

Figure 2: New York Times Articles Mentioning Racialized Terms By Agency, 2005-2025



Aggregated Measures of Racialization We further aggregate all articles from 2005 to 2025 to create two measures of racialization. The first measure of racialized attention is the count of the number of articles mentioning racialized words. Figure 4 shows these counts. The second measures the share of articles using racial terms by dividing this count by the total number of articles mentioning each agency. Both of these measures are rescaled by taking the square root of the count (to stabilize the variance), subtracting the mean (to make the scale mean 0), and dividing by the standard deviation (to make the standard deviation 1).

Figure 3: New York Times Total Articles Mentioning a Federal Agency and Racialized Words 2005-2025

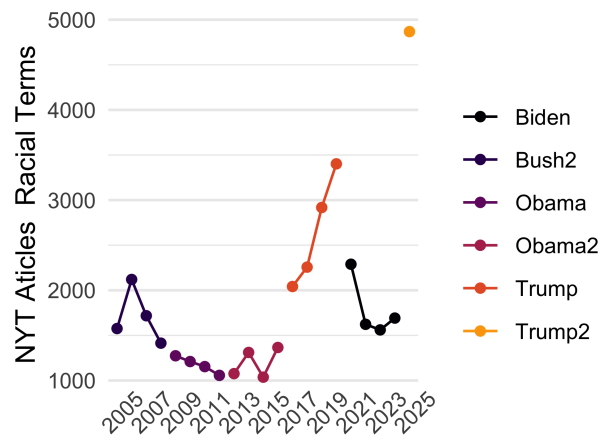
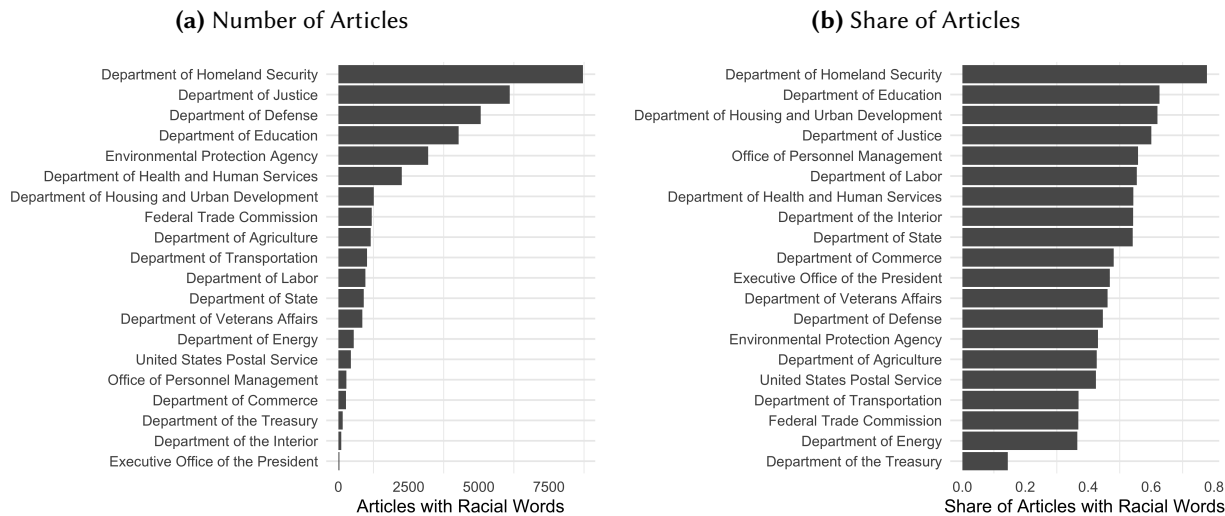


Figure 4: Racialized Words in New York Times Articles, 2005-2025



3.3 Policy Texts

Data

Using the regulation.gov API, we pull all rulemaking documents, subset to proposed and final rules, and then count the number of documents mentioning racialized terms for all agencies that published more than 10 rules from 2005-2025.

Over Time Trends Figure 5 shows trends over time in mentions of racial terms in agency rules for select agencies. They show attention to race and racial disparities in policy increased at some agencies and decreased at others over time. For example, more Department of Transportation (DOT) rules mentioned Affirmative Action and Asian Americans in the second Bush administration than in any subsequent administration. The DOT Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) also saw a massive spike in orders mentioning “Citizenship” related to a post-9/11 policy requiring owners of U.S.-based air carriers, including shipping companies and air taxis (small planes for hire), to prove that they were owned and effectively controlled by US citizens. This resulted in many businesses losing licenses and investigations into ownership and control, including DHL and Virgin America. In contrast, the EPA and FDA have increased nearly all racialized terms over the past 20 years, from near zero at the beginning of the Obama Administration to much higher levels, especially during the Biden administration, likely reflecting increased attention to Environmental Justice and attention to racial disparities in public health. Figure 6 shows the time trend aggregated across all agencies.

Aggregated Measures of Racialization As with the NYT data, we aggregate all proposed and final rules from 2005 to 2025 to create two measures of racialization. The first measure is the count of proposed and final rules using one or more racialized words. Figure 7 shows these counts. Because some agencies make more policies per year than others, the second measures the share of proposed and final rules by dividing this count by the total number of proposed and final rules published by the agency. As with the other measures, both of these measures are rescaled by taking the square root of the count (to stabilize the variance), subtracting the mean (to make the scale mean 0), and dividing by the standard deviation (to make the standard deviation 1).

Figure 5: Agency Rules with Racialized Language, by Agency, 2005-2025

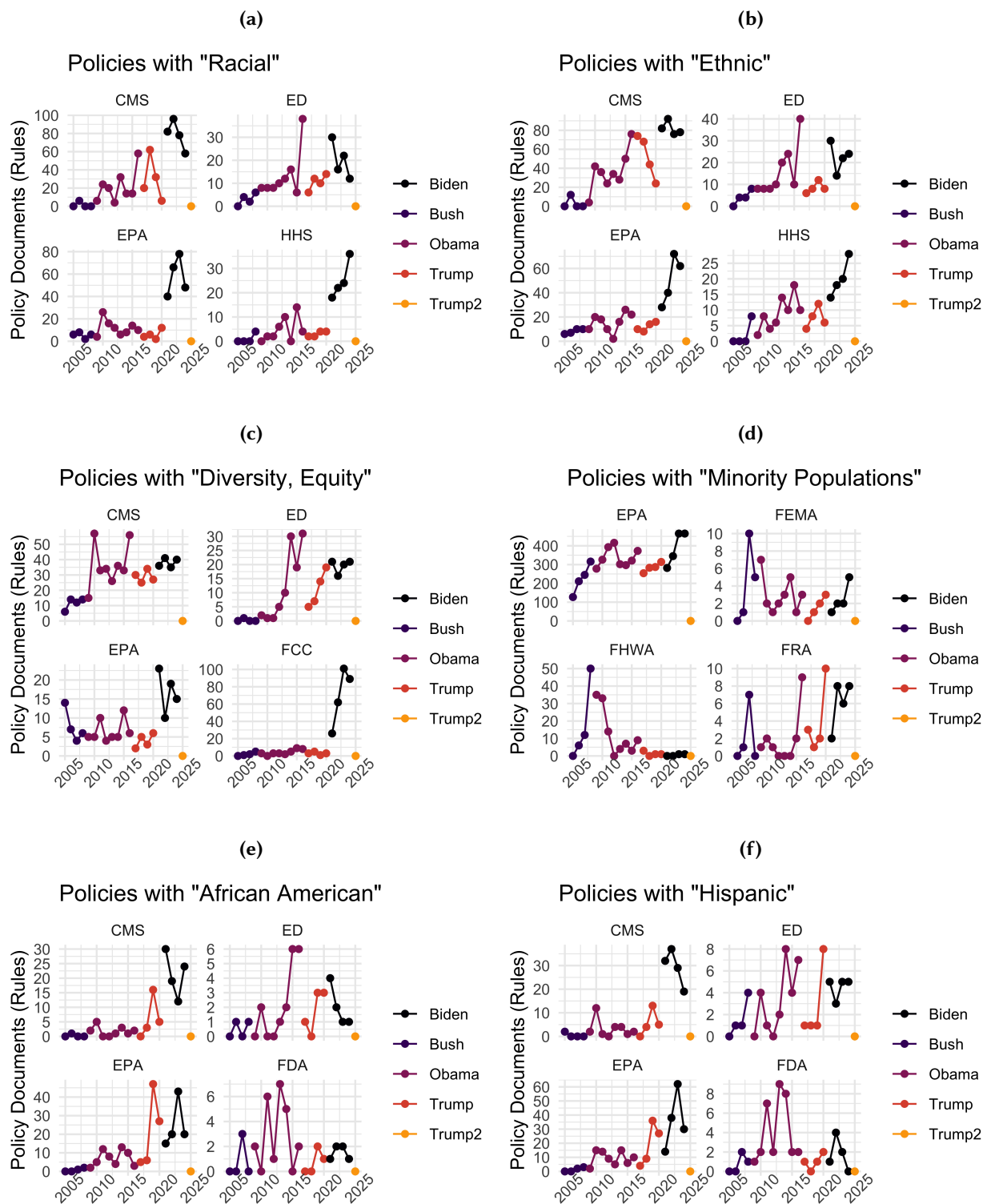


Figure 6: Agency Rules with Racialized Language, 2005-2025

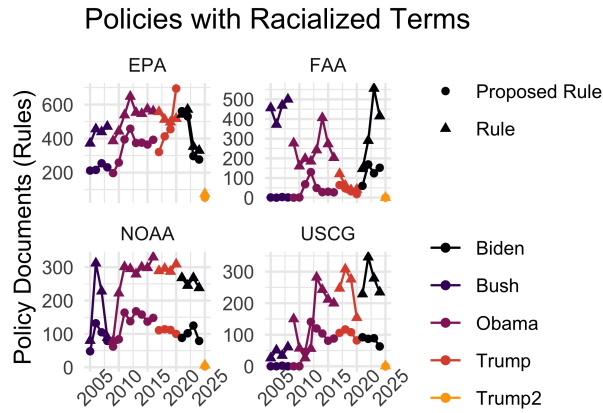
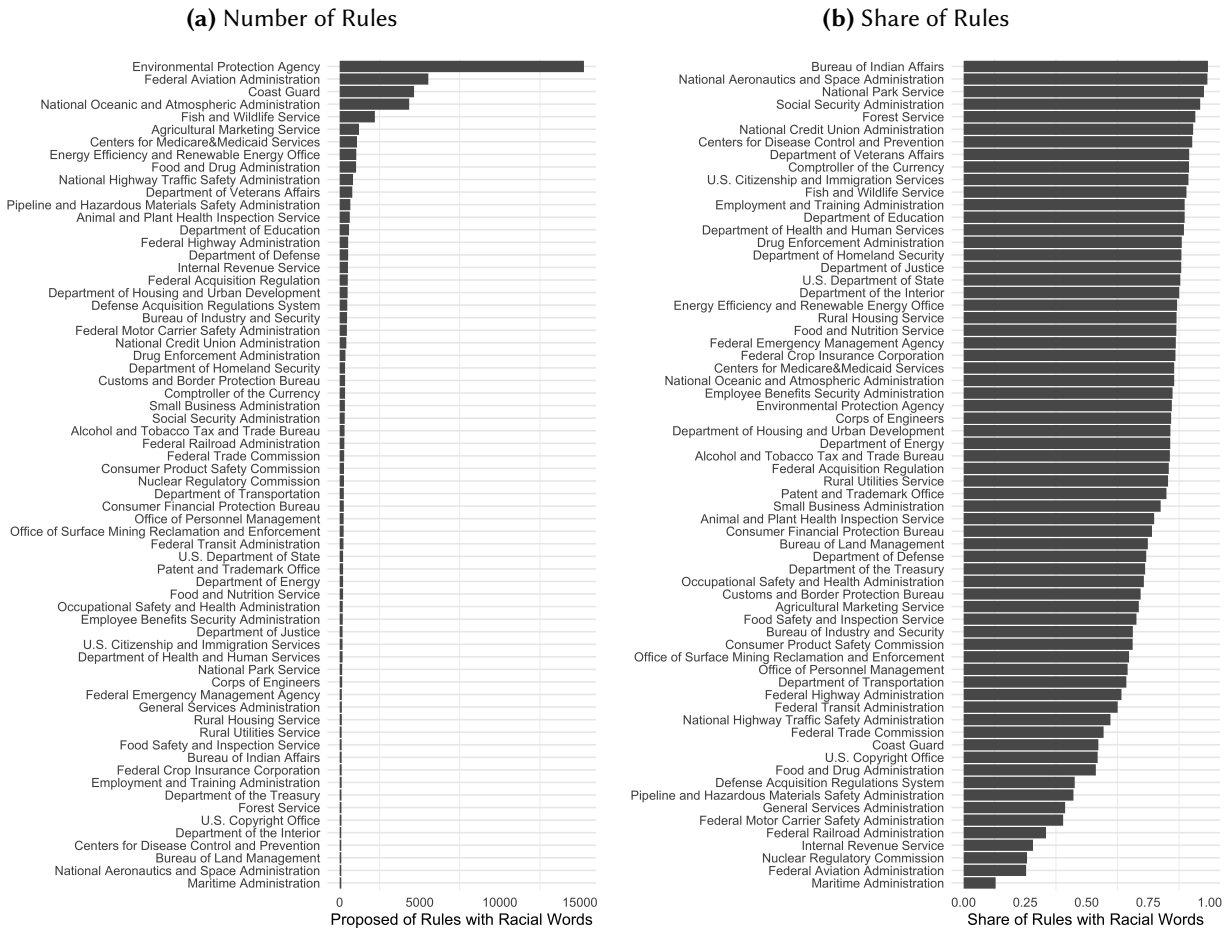


Figure 7: Racialized Words in Agency Rules, 2005-2025.



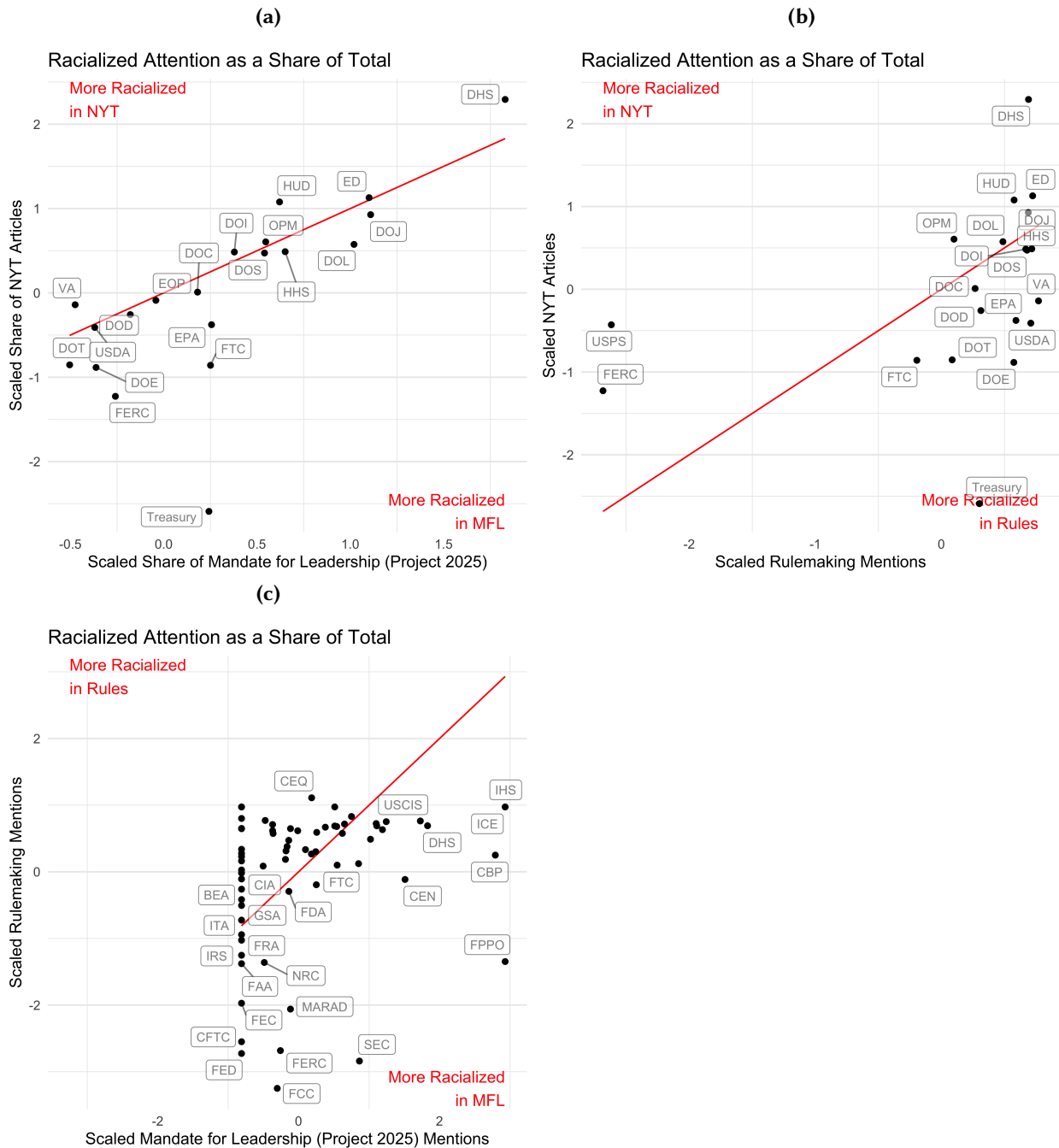
3.4 Comparing Racialization Across Contexts

Figure 8 compares (a) racialization scores from New York Times (NYT) articles and from the Mandate for Leadership (MFL) reports. Agencies above the red diagonal line have higher scores for the NYT measure. Agencies below the line have higher scores from the MFL measure. The correlation between the NYT and MFL measures is 0.74 ($p = 0$). The largest outlier is the Department of Housing and Urban Development, which is discussed in more racialized terms in NYT articles. Most agencies have higher scores on the MFL measure.

Figure 8 compares (b) racialization scores from rulemaking documents and from NYT articles. Agencies above the red diagonal line have higher scores for the NYT measure. Agencies below the line have higher scores from the MFL measure. The correlation between the RULES and NYT measures is 0.38 ($p = 0.1$). One of the largest outliers is again the Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD), which is discussed in more racialized terms in NYT articles. The Department of State (DOS) publishes rules that contain racialized language much more frequently than the NYT coverage of DOS uses racialized language. The Departments of Education (ED), Justice (DOJ), Homeland Security (DHS), and Labor (DOL) are fairly high on both measures. Most agencies have slightly higher scores on the rulemaking measure.

Figure 8 compares (c) racialization scores from rulemaking documents and the Project 2025 Mandate for Leadership. Agencies above the red diagonal line have higher scores for the rulemaking measure. Agencies below the line have higher scores from the MFL measure. The correlation between the RULES and MFL measures is 0.25 ($p = 0.04$). The Department of State, Veterans Affairs (VA), and the Department of Commerce Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) use relatively more racialized terms in rulemaking. Compared to the language of their rules, Project 2025 uses more racialized language in discussing Customs and Border Protection (CBP), the Bureau of Land Management (BLM), and the US Coast Guard (USCG).

Figure 8: Racialization in Rulemaking vs. Project 2025 vs. New York Times



4 Racialization and Perceived Ideology

To create a single measure of racialization, we take the average of racialization scores from each context (advocacy agendas, policy documents, media coverage). While many studies will want to use or compare racialization in particular contexts, this combined racialization scale offers a single number, similar to perceived ideology scales (e.g., [Richardson \(2019\)](#)). One combined scale allows for comparisons with other scales, like perceived ideology shown in Figure 9.

Racialization is not significantly correlated with perceived ideology. Instead, some highly racialized agencies are perceived as “liberal” (most prominently, the Departments of Education and Housing and Urban Development) while others are perceived as “conservative” (mostly parts of the Department of Homeland Security). Other parts of Homeland Security that are perceived as more centrist, including FEMA and USCIS, are nevertheless strongly racialized. The Department of Justice, Federal Highway Administration (FHWA), and Food and Drug Administration (FDA) are also racialized while being perceived as fairly moderate.

Interestingly, agencies like the Department of Defense and the Environmental Protection Agency are rarely discussed in racialized terms in the media and advocacy agendas, despite being perceived as highly polarized and making policies with racial implications. For example, EPA has long led the government’s work on environmental racism and environmental justice. As a large employer of low-income Americans, the Department of Defense’s policy has racialized consequences. Despite being perceived as having strong conservative or liberal associations, their programs are not usually discussed in racialized terms.

Racialization is positively correlated with perceived ideological extremism ($p < 0.05$), but this correlation is not strong (0.22). This relationship is statistically significant in the Project 2025 Mandate for Leadership context, not for policy documents or media coverage. Figure 10 shows the absolute value of the [Richardson \(2019\)](#) score on the x-axis and our combined score on the y-axis. Agencies in the upper left have high racialization scores by ideology scores near zero (the mean of all of these scales). Agencies in the upper right have high racialization scores and strong “liberal” or strong “conservative” perceptions. Agencies at the bottom vary in perceived ideology but are all low in racialization.

Figure 9: Correlation Between Racialization and Perceived Ideology

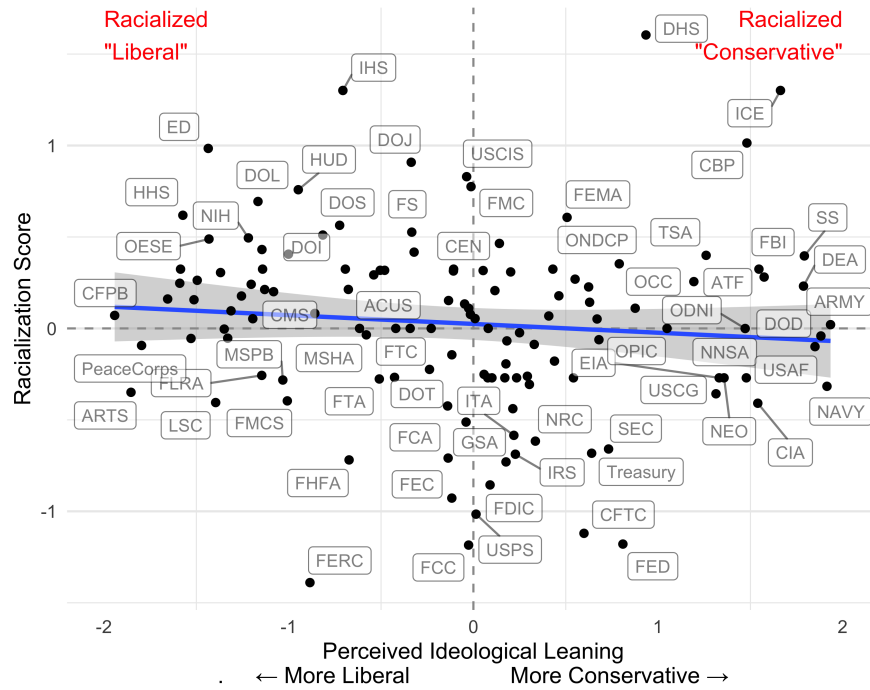
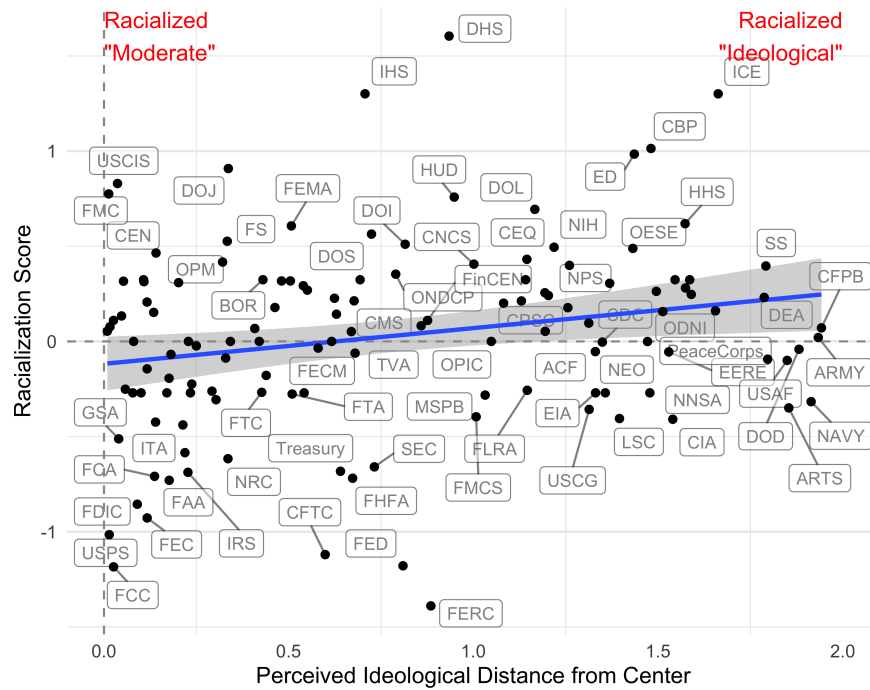


Figure 10: Correlation Between Racialization and Perceived Ideology



5 Conclusion

This study contributes to the growing understanding of how federal agencies are racialized by introducing a new measure that captures the tension between racial progress and obstruction within agency policies. By integrating both ideological and racialized perspectives, we offer a more nuanced understanding of how agency structures, leadership, and policy responsibilities influence racial inequality. Our approach captures how policymakers, the media, and advocates frame agency policies in racial terms. In doing so, our measure provides a systematic way to examine variation in the racialization of federal agencies across institutions and over time.

5.1 Implications for Bureaucracy Scholarship

Our findings that racialization is correlated across sources as ideologically distant as the New York Times and Heritage Foundation suggest that this construct meaningfully shapes public discourse across venues and ideological camps.

The association between a given agency and racialized language varies significantly over time, with some agencies seeing more and some seeing less, despite their core missions staying the same. This suggests that racialization is about *more than how agency missions and programs affect racial inequality*. Framing processes must also be at work to re-cast certain missions and programs in ways that emphasize race and racial inequality. These may include efforts to push institutions to confront the disparate impacts of the policies they study. They may also include efforts to legitimize, delegitimize, polarize, or depolarize public perceptions of certain institutions.

Our finding that racialized language is associated with perceived ideological extremism (where ideological refers to “conservative” and “liberal”) suggests that racialization may indeed reduce perceptions that agencies are “centrist” or “neutral.” Alternatively, it may reflect that controversial or polarized government programs are more likely to be cast in a racialized light by opponents (or perhaps racial justice advocates who see directly confronting race as a necessary part of the controversy).

Additionally, our measure highlights agencies perceived as “centrist,” such as FEMA, that do not attract significant media or elite attention. Understanding why certain agencies face less scrutiny is crucial. Further research should explore why some agencies, which one might expect to be racialized, are not perceived as such. Investigating why some agencies, particularly those operating in policy areas where racial disparities are well documented, are not perceived as racialized may reveal important dynamics about institutional visibility, agenda setting, and political conflict.

These scores enable new research questions. To what extent does racialization (e.g., by advocates or the media) make agencies targets for political actors? Or does increased attention to race by policymakers lead

to different media coverage? Are racialized institutions more responsive to claims of racial injustice in their policy? Does institutional racialization lead to greater change in the racial disparities in policy outcomes?

Taken together, these questions allow scholars to examine the direction of influence between public discourse and policymaking. Specifically, future research can investigate whether racialized media narratives shape how agencies are perceived and politicized, or whether policy decisions and institutional actions themselves drive the racialization of agencies in public discourse.

Another important extension of this measure is the ability to connect contemporary racialization scores to the historical racialization of federal agencies. Future research could link these scores to measures capturing how agencies responded to racial progress during and after the civil rights era, such as whether they resisted, complied with, or actively implemented civil rights reforms. Doing so would allow scholars to examine whether agencies with historically resistant or exclusionary records continue to be perceived as racialized institutions today.

This approach also opens the door to examining whether agencies with more racialized institutional histories are more likely to participate in contemporary racial discourse or attract media and political attention related to race. In turn, scholars could explore whether these historical patterns shape how agencies are perceived today and whether institutions with deeper histories of racial conflict or inequality remain more closely associated with debates about race and racial justice.

5.2 Next Steps

Dynamic Racialization Scores In Section 3.2 and Section 3.3, we present over-time trends. Yet, the measures in Section 3.4 and Section 4 average out these trends to arrive at one number for the 2005-2025 period. In part, this is because prior copies of the Mandate for Leadership reports are difficult to access and digitize, and thus, we only have one year for this key source. With more data points, we will be able to calculate the combined measure at more points in time, thus allowing comparisons of how relative racialization across sources has changed over time.

By analyzing these dynamics, we gain critical insights into why federal agencies are strategically targeted by political actors and media organizations across different presidential administrations. Dynamic racialization scores will facilitate comparison with dynamic ideology scores (Acs, 2025).

In addition, we hope to incorporate a more systematic historical analysis of federal agencies to better understand how institutional histories shape contemporary patterns of racialization. In particular, we plan to examine agencies' resistance to or urgency in establishing and supporting civil rights reforms, such as the development and enforcement of Title VIII offices (Walton, 1988). Doing so will allow us to assess whether

agencies that were historically slower to adopt or implement civil rights protections are more likely to be perceived as racialized in contemporary policy discourse. This approach also allows us to examine how the origins of agencies themselves reflect particular ideological and racialized policy contexts. For example, agencies such as the Department of Homeland Security emerged from policy debates deeply shaped by racialized concerns around immigration, national security, and surveillance. Taken together, linking these historical patterns to our racialization scores will help illuminate how federal agencies operate as racialized institutions whose histories, policy domains, and political contexts continue to shape how they are understood and contested in public discourse.

Appendix

A NYT mentions of “Racial”

In the paper, we show trends for mentions of all racialized terms combined. As a more conservative measure, we show trends just for articles using the word “racial.” Of 146,491 articles mentioning agencies from 2005 to 2025, 38,965 also mentioned the word “racial.”

Over Time Trends

Figure A1 shows the number of articles containing the word “racial” by year for selected agencies. Figure A2 shows the same trend as Figure A1 aggregated across agencies. Overall, the frequency of racialized articles mentioning agencies peaked in 2020, the end of the first Trump Administration, with 2021, the first year of the Biden administration, being the second highest. This likely reflects the larger national racial reckoning in US public discourse ignited by the police killings of Black individuals and subsequent racial justice protests.

Figure A1: New York Times Articles Mentioning “Racial” By Agency, 2005-2025

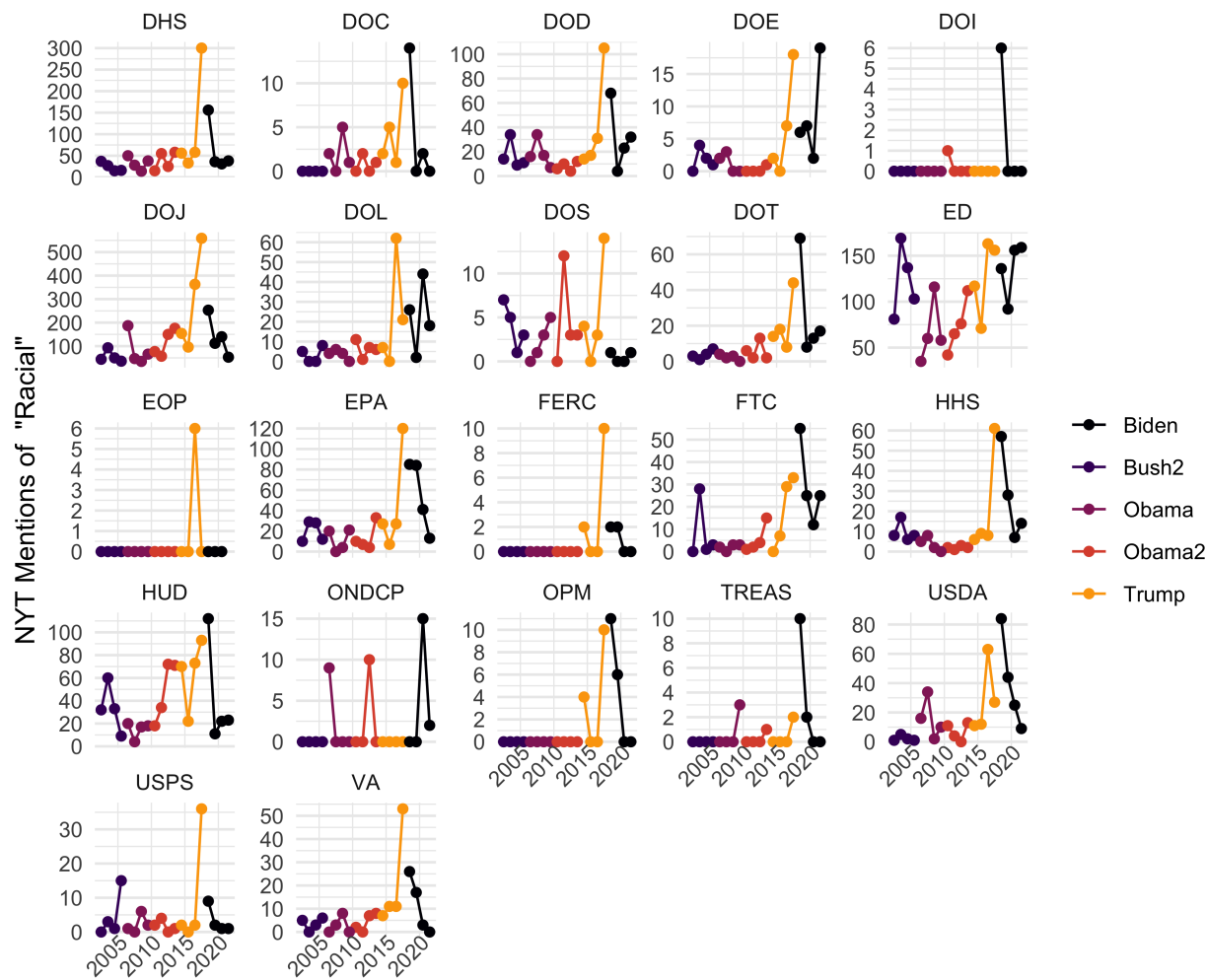
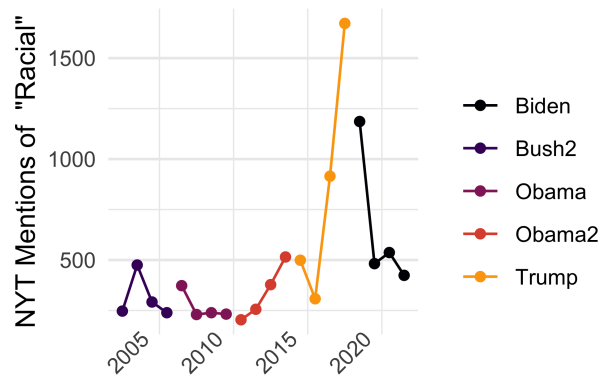


Figure A2: New York Times Total Articles Mentioning a Federal Agency and “Racial,” 2005-2025



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